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Trust it or not: Understanding users' motivations and strategies for assessing the credibility of AI-generated information

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Abstract

The evolution of artificial intelligence (AI) facilitates the creation of multimodal information of mixed quality, intensifying the challenges individuals face when assessing information credibility. Through in-depth interviews with users of generative AI platforms, this study investigates the underlying motivations and multidimensional approaches people use to assess the credibility of AI-generated information. Four major motivations driving users to authenticate information are identified: expectancy violation, task features, personal involvement, and pre-existing attitudes. Users evaluate AI-generated information's credibility using both internal (e.g. relying on AI affordances, content integrity, and subjective expertise) and external approaches (e.g. iterative

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interaction, cross-validation, and practical testing). Theoretical and practical implications are discussed in the context of AI-generated content assessment.

Keywords
Credibility assessment, generative AI, human–AI interaction, motivations

The advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) has revolutionized the creation, alteration, and distribution of multimodal information of mixed quality (Fui-Hoon Nah et al., 2023). Generative AI, which draws on neural networks to learn synthesis rules from extensive datasets, offers a novel approach to creating seemingly high-quality yet potentially false information (Ooi et al., 2023). This development potentially complicates the information ecosystem (e.g. Dwivedi et al., 2023), raising critical questions: Do humans trust the information generated by AI? What makes them trust or distrust such information? Can people discern the authenticity of AI-generated information? Considering the credibility issues associated with AI technological advances (Goh, 2024; Shin, 2023, 2024), such as the possibility of generative AI being a source of misinformation (Monteith et al., 2024), understanding human-centric approaches to assessing the credibility of AI-generated information is important for navigating the intricate information environments of the AI era.

Existing research on the verification of AI-generated content has primarily concentrated on algorithmic detection methods (e.g. machine learning classifiers and deep neural networks; Khemani et al., 2024) or manual fact-checking (Himma-Kadakas and Ojamets, 2022). Although a hybrid approach—integrating human intelligence with algorithmic detection—has proven effective in addressing the limitations of purely algorithmic methods (Demartini et al., 2020), the specific ways in which humans engage in the multifaceted processes of evaluating the credibility of AI-generated content are not well understood (Demartini et al., 2020). This gap underscores the need for a deeper understanding of human-centric approaches which could significantly enhance the effectiveness of algorithm-driven fact-checking (Demartini et al., 2020). In an era where credibility judgments are becoming increasingly complex, relying solely on superficial cues or individual cognition is insufficient (Fui-Hoon Nah et al., 2023). Therefore, exploring how individuals utilize various approaches to assess the credibility of AI-generated information is a critical yet under-researched area (Metzger and Flanagin, 2015; Shin et al., 2024a).

In addition, while a few studies have identified strategies individuals employ to assess the veracity of AI-facilitated visual information, such as analyzing surface cues and cross-checking (e.g. Goh, 2024; Thomson et al., 2022), the motivations driving these credibility assessments remain underexplored. Scholars argue that individuals do not automatically engage in credibility assessments without sufficient motivation (Metzger, 2007; Ou and Ho, 2024a). This highlights the need to understand these motivations to promote effective authentication behaviors and address the growing challenge of misinformation in the AI era (Qian et al., 2023). Exploring users' motivations behind credibility assessments of AI-produced information is thus especially pertinent.

Drawing upon the theory of interactive media effects for human–AI interaction (HAII-TIME model; Sundar, 2020) and the audience authentication acts (AAA)

framework (Tandoc et al., 2018), this study has two aims. First, through qualitative in-depth interviews with users of generative AI platforms, it seeks to understand how individuals engage in various cognitive and behavioral processes to assess the credibility of AI-generated information. Second, it explores the motivations underpinning these credibility assessments. Specifically, the HAII-TIME model suggests that individuals base their trust in AI and its outputs on the attributes (e.g. interface and algorithms) of and their interactions with the systems. The AAA framework proposes that individuals utilize a combination of internal (e.g. relying on personal cognition, the source, and the message) and external strategies (e.g. seeking information from external sources) to evaluate information credibility. Theoretically, findings from this study could deepen our understanding of individuals' multifaceted strategies involved in their credibility assessment processes of AI-generated information and enrich the credibility assessment literature by integrating insights from human–AI interactions. In addition, it identifies the circumstances that motivate people to employ various information evaluation strategies in AI contexts.

Literature review

Credibility assessment in the age of generative AI

Information credibility judgment, defined as "individuals' subjective judgment of the veracity of communication content" (Appelman and Sundar, 2016: 5), has been a significant focus of research in recent decades. Studies have identified multiple factors that influence these assessments, including informational elements (such as source, content, and channel) and individual factors (such as personal knowledge) (Metzger and Flanagin, 2015; Ou and Ho, 2024b). The rise of generative AI has introduced complexities in assessing credibility, particularly through its ability to produce information that appears accurate but is factually incorrect—a phenomenon referred to as "hallucination," which blurs the lines between authentic and AI-generated content (Alkaissi and McFarlane, 2023). This issue is prevalent across various types of AI algorithms, including language models and image generators (Alkaissi and McFarlane, 2023). On one hand, generative AI models facilitate the swift creation of highly realistic texts, images, and videos, including deepfakes, which closely mimic human-generated content (Helmus, 2022; Xu et al., 2023), complicating the determination of authenticity based solely on traditional cues like source reputation or content quality. On another, the opacity and lack of transparency in the generative processes of AI—such as the uncertain originality of the data and the often-opaque algorithmic operations (Shin et al., 2024b)—obscure traditional credibility markers, such as author identity or publication source. This makes it increasingly challenging for individuals to rely on these cues when judging credibility. Collectively, the growing prevalence of generative AI underscores the necessity for multifaceted and human–AI collaborative approaches in fact-checking to effectively assess information credibility (Xu et al., 2023).

Previous studies have documented individuals' strategies for judging the veracity of AI-generated information (e.g. Goh, 2024; Qian et al., 2023). For instance, Thomson et al. (2022) demonstrated that journalists often verify AI-powered visual information

through reverse image searches, analysis of light and shadow, and scrutiny of image metadata. Goh (2024) found that laypersons base their credibility judgments of AI-created videos on media features (e.g. surface video and audio cues like graphical anomalies, behavioral inconsistencies, and content quality), their own knowledge, and additional search outcomes. However, these studies have overlooked the role of AI features and user interactions with AI systems in credibility assessments. Extant experiments suggested that AI transparency (i.e. the disclosure of the rationales behind its decision-making processes; Larsson and Heintz, 2020) significantly reduces users' uncertainty perceptions and enhances their trust in AI-generated decisions (Liu, 2021). Similarly, Liew et al. (2023) found that information from an AI-powered chatbot is perceived as more trustworthy and objective. This suggests that individuals also depend on AI characteristics and their interactions with AI systems to evaluate AI-generated content. Building on this, our study will extend traditional literature on credibility assessment by incorporating insights from human–AI interaction dynamics, providing a more comprehensive framework for understanding how people evaluate the credibility of AI-generated information.

The HAII-TIME model

Sundar (2020) introduced the HAII-TIME model, a framework based on the Theory of Interactive Media Effects (TIME), specifically designed for studying the psychosocial processes of human–AI interaction (HAII). This model is particularly tailored to explore how users' perceptions and trust in AI are shaped by AI features (e.g. interface manifestations and algorithmic attributes) and their interactions with the system. This, in turn, affects their processing and evaluation of AI-generated content. Unlike previous theoretical frameworks (e.g. technology acceptance model) which primarily emphasize static factors (e.g. perceived usefulness and ease of use), the HAII-TIME model extends beyond these traditional psychological mechanisms. It focuses on not only the roles of AI attributes but the dynamics of HAII in explaining trust in AI, viewing trust as a component of a broader, ongoing interactive experience rather than an assessment made prior to use.

The HAII-TIME model proposes that AI features can impact the outcomes of human–AI interactions, such as trust in AI, via two primary routes: cues and actions. In the cue route, both observable attributes (like the system interface) and unobservable attributes (such as algorithmic functions) of AI can activate users' cognitive heuristics—mental shortcuts rooted in pre-existing beliefs—that then shape their psychological responses to both the AI system and its outputs. Empirical studies demonstrate that perceiving AI as a specialist rather than a generalist can activate expertise-related heuristics, thereby enhancing trust in the AI (Koh and Sundar, 2010). In addition, increasing AI transparency by disclosing its machine learning processes has been shown to further enhance trust in its decisions (Liu, 2021).

The action route in the HAII-TIME model is activated through user interactions with the AI system, suggesting that these interactions, enabled by AI features, can significantly influence engagement and trust in the system (Kang and Lou, 2022; Sundar, 2020). Key elements of user-AI interactions include agency negotiation—whether users

are passively guided by the AI or exert control over it through customization and control functions—and mutual augmentation, which refers to the reciprocal enhancement of AI and human capabilities in the process of human–AI synergy. For instance, existing research on AI-integrated social media platforms like TikTok shows that human–AI synergy, facilitated by AI affordances such as content creation, curation, and social networking, significantly influences user engagement. This leads to psychological absorption and prolonged interactions with the platform (Kang and Lou, 2022).

Generative AI, known for its proficiency in comprehending complex queries and generating dynamic responses, potentially marks a paradigm shift in user-AI interactions (Faruk et al., 2023). Unlike AI-curated media platforms that have been extensively studied, such as TikTok, which specifically serves as an information distributor and tailors content for users (e.g. Kang and Lou, 2022), generative AI primarily acts as a communication source, autonomously creating content for its users. Users' dynamic credibility assessments of content from generative AI can reflect the propositions of the HAII-TIME model. For example, users may either accept the machine's agency by taking the generated content as is or assert control over it through follow-up prompts, feedback, or customization (i.e. agency negotiation). Such dynamic interactions not only enhance AI's performance but also evolve human communication practices (i.e. mutual agency augmentation) (Endacott, 2024; Kang and Lou, 2022). The capabilities of generative AI facilitate unique HAII dynamics and raise important questions about how users process AI-generated information, what factors influence their acceptance or rejection of its content, and how they form credibility judgments based on the AI's affordances and their dynamic interactions with it. To explore the mechanisms through which the affordances and dynamic interactions with generative AI shape users' credibility assessments of AI-generated content, the HAII-TIME model could provide valuable insights through the lens of human–AI interaction.

The AAA framework

The AAA framework (Tandoc et al., 2018) was proposed to understand how audiences evaluate news credibility they have encountered on social media. It outlines two types of information authentication strategies: internal and external acts of authentication. Specifically, when encountering a piece of information with uncertain truthfulness online, individuals tend to first engage in internal authentication, relying on personal cognition (e.g. personal gut feelings, knowledge, and experience), information source (e.g. the legitimacy of information senders), and content (e.g. quality) to judge the credibility. If the internal assessment confirms the truthfulness, the process concludes; otherwise, it progresses to external authentication, which includes actively seeking or passively encountering additional information from external sources (e.g. interpersonal or institutional sources), to verify the information. Such transitions from internal to external credibility assessment processes are well-documented by existing research. For instance, Torres et al. (2018) observed that initial doubts about credibility, often rooted in assessments of the source, typically prompt further behavioral verification. Moreover, some studies have demonstrated that engagement in external verification behaviors is influenced by factors such as the perceived significance of the information (Sun, 2022),

individual knowledge and literacy levels (Chan, 2022), and personal attitudes toward the information (Pundir et al., 2021).

Unlike most existing theoretical frameworks, such as dual-processing models (Metzger, 2007), which primarily focus on internal or cognitive approaches to credibility assessment (e.g. Sundar, 2007; Wathen and Burkell, 2002) and tend to overlook external or behavioral verification methods, the AAA framework proposes a more holistic process. This framework encompasses both internal and external credibility judgment processes. Such a comprehensive approach is particularly crucial in the context of AI-generated content, where distinguishing between credible and non-credible information is increasingly challenging due to the AI-facilitated generation and dissemination of misinformation (Fui-Hoon Nah et al., 2023). Therefore, there is a need for a thorough examination of AI-generated information through cross-validation and behavioral verification in the complex, AI-driven information environment. Consequently, this study adopts the AAA framework, conceptualizing the credibility assessment of AI-generated content as a fusion of both internal and external assessments. This offers a more robust conceptual foundation to explore how individuals assess the credibility of AI-generated information.

Despite the comprehensive credibility assessment processes outlined by the AAA framework, one notable limitation is its assumption that individuals invariably engage in information credibility assessments (Edgerly et al., 2020), without considering the motivations behind their engagement or disengagement. Previous research indicates that individuals are less inclined to evaluate scientific information on novel foods unless they perceive the information as relevant or potentially harmful (Ou and Ho, 2024a). Similarly, Waruwu et al. (2021) found that people are more likely to verify social media news that impacts themselves and their social relationships, viewing such verification as a way to maintain their self-image and enhance group cohesion. These findings suggest that the decision to assess the credibility of AI-generated information may depend on various individual motivations. Therefore, this study aims to refine the AAA framework within the context of HAII by exploring the underlying motivations driving people's credibility assessments of AI-generated content.

Theoretical synthesis

The use of generative AI to produce information is becoming increasingly common, yet how people respond to such information remains largely unexplored. This highlights the need for a deeper understanding of what influences people to believe or disbelieve AI-generated content and how they might verify its accuracy if they question its truthfulness. This study integrates the theoretical perspectives of the HAII-TIME model with the AAA framework to investigate this emerging area. There are several reasons for this integration. First, while the AAA framework provides a comprehensive approach to assessing information credibility through internal and external methods, it does not account for the nuances of HAIIs, which significantly influence credibility judgments (Sundar, 2020). Previous research has shown that AI affordances (e.g. content creation, curation, and online networking; Kang and Lou, 2022), along with human–AI agency collaboration (Fui-Hoon Nah et al., 2023), enhance user

engagement and decision-making. In addition, integrating the HAII-TIME model's emphasis on human–AI interaction with the AAA framework's credibility assessment processes enriches our understanding of how mutual augmentation or negotiation between humans and AI is reflected in the credibility assessment process. This integration allows us to see how humans enhance AI performance by providing feedback on generated content, while AI supports human credibility assessments by efficiently providing information that informs credibility decisions.

According to the AAA framework, the evaluation process begins with an internal assessment, where individuals assess cues from the content, the delivery channel, and their own cognitive evaluations. The HAII-TIME model can enrich this internal assessment by emphasizing how the features of the AI system (as an information channel) and AI-generated content influence credibility evaluations, thus deepening the understanding of the role AI affordances play in the internal credibility assessment. In addition, for external verification outlined in the AAA framework, the HAII-TIME model could provide insights into how interactions with AI—such as providing feedback and posing follow-up questions—can enhance the external verification of AI-generated information. By integrating these two frameworks, this research aims to elucidate the complex and dynamic processes through which individuals assess AI-generated information and the underlying motivations for their evaluations. This theoretical synthesis underscores the need for a holistic approach to understanding the credibility assessment of AI-generated content in an increasingly digital age. Consequently, this study poses the following research questions:

RQ1: How do users characterize their motivations for assessing the credibility of AI-generated information?

RQ2: How do users describe their approaches to assessing the credibility of AI-generated information?

Method

Data collection

We employed a qualitative approach (i.e. semi-structured in-depth interviews) to address the research questions. This qualitative method was chosen because the current knowledge on the credibility assessment of AI-generated content is in its infancy and underexplored. The use of the interview method, an exploratory approach, enables us to gain rich data and a nuanced understanding of people's credibility assessment of AI-generated information by allowing diverse opinions or perceptions to be expressed (Tracy, 2020). Moreover, the semi-structured interviews not only allowed us to deductively address the research questions deriving from theories but also inductively analyze collected data and derive new theoretical insights.

After receiving ethics approval from the Institutional Review Board of a local university, we recruited participants through snowball and purposive sampling methods via social media and participants' personal social networks. More specifically, selection criteria included availability, willingness to participate, prior experience with generative AI

platforms, and diversity in occupations and academic disciplines. In addition, referrals from current participants helped expand our pool. The use of purposive sampling strategies allowed for the selection of participants who were directly relevant to our research questions, based on predefined criteria. In addition, snowball sampling enabled us to access a broader network of participants across various occupations and disciplines that utilized generative AI. Together, these methods ensured a diverse and well-informed group of participants for our study.

Participants' recruitment stopped when the data reached a state of theoretical saturation (i.e. no additional insights could be found whereby the researcher could develop more properties of a specific theoretical category; Saunders et al., 2018). Therefore, in our case, when the researchers began to hear the same opinions and comments repeatedly concerning most of the interview questions, data saturation was achieved, and no more participants were recruited (Grady, 1998). To ensure we gained diversified insights from all gender groups across different disciplines, we maintained an equal gender proportion and kept an equal number of participants from science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) and Arts fields.

A total of 30 participants took part in the in-depth interviews from October to November 2023, including 14 males and 16 females. All participants were aged from 19–35 (M_{age}=23.77, SD_{age}=4.18), and 15 of them were from STEM disciplines (e.g. computer science, civil engineering, mathematics, and physics) and 15 were from Arts disciplines (e.g. social sciences, humanities, communication, and information management). Most of them received a bachelor's degree. The 30 interviewees used various generative AI platforms, such as ChatGPT by OpenAI, WenXinYiYan by Baidu, Bard AI by Google, and MidJourney, with the majority utilizing ChatGPT. Notably, almost all of them used generative AI for over 180 mins a week, employing it for diverse purposes including translation, brainstorming, generating texts and codes, searching for information, polishing writing, data analysis, and companionship.

All interviews were conducted by two well-trained research assistants using a semi-structured interview guide, which was developed based on the study's objectives and relevant theories, such as the AAA framework and the HAII-TIME model. This guide included questions that probed participants' trust in and use of generative AI platforms, their strategies for assessing the content credibility, and their motivations for these assessments. To ensure the reliability and professionalism of the in-depth interviews, we adhered to established practices (e.g. Dicicco-Bloom and Crabtree, 2006; Patton, 2014; Wiles, 2012). Specifically, all interviewers underwent comprehensive training, which included reviewing the interview guidelines and learning about the participants' backgrounds. Pilot interviews were carried out to refine their interviewing techniques (Rubin and Rubin, 2011). Informed consent was obtained from all participants before each interview to uphold research ethical standards. Moreover, to facilitate open and honest communication, interviewers were trained to engage sincerely with participants, demonstrating empathy, asking probing questions for clarity, and avoiding any displays of bias or interruptions (Patton, 2014). Each participant received CNY 50 for their participation. The interviews, lasting approximately one hour each, were conducted via Tencent Meeting and audio-recorded for transcription. The interviews were transcribed verbatim and translated from Chinese to English by two research assistants and

researchers, with all participant identifiers removed to ensure their confidentiality, that is, each participant's name was replaced by an alphanumeric code (e.g. P1 refers to Participant 1).

Data analysis

Two research assistants from our project team received rigorous training to independently code the transcribed data. To ensure transparency, rigor, and reliability in our data analysis, we followed established criteria for qualitative analysis, including credibility, dependability, transferability, and confirmability (Lincoln and Guba, 1985; Ou and Ho, 2024a). A hybrid coding method, combining open coding, axial coding, and selective coding, was utilized (Tracy, 2020). In the open-coding stage, two coders independently read and coded all transcripts line-by-line to generate initial codes (e.g. "broader training data" and "strong algorithmic models"), based on the specificity, frequency, extensiveness, and similarity of mentions by the participants (Krueger and Casey, 2000). The two coders independently coded all transcripts, constantly comparing their generated codes and modifying them to reflect the data more accurately. In the axial coding stage, the two coders discussed and synthesized the codes generated in the first stage, associating and categorizing them into higher-level codes (e.g. "AI affordances/features"). During this stage, the extant literature and theories on information credibility assessment and trust in AI served as guidance for the categorization and definition of these higher-level codes. In the selective coding stage, the researchers and coders identified the core categories and larger theoretical-driven themes through discussions based on both the lower-level categories identified and their relevance to the literature, theoretical framework, and research questions.

Results

Motivations for assessing the credibility of AI-generated information

Regarding RQ1, our analysis identified four major motivations driving participants to authenticate the information provided by generative AI systems: expectancy violation, task features, personal involvement, and pre-existing attitudes toward generative AI (see Figure 1).

Expectancy violation. Many interviewees (e.g. P5, P7, P18, and P25) hold positive expectations toward generative AI platforms, believing that these systems have robust information-processing and information-generating capabilities that can effectively address many of the challenges they encounter in their work and studies. However, they also reported that when AI-generated information failed to meet these expectations—specifically, when the quality and accuracy of the content did not align with their anticipated standards (Burgoon and Hale, 1988)—they perceived the AI as less intelligent and closely scrutinized the credibility of the content. For instance, P5, who frequently used generative AI for copyediting and proofreading and viewed AI as a more competent and efficient copyeditor than humans, noted that upon encountering repetitive or

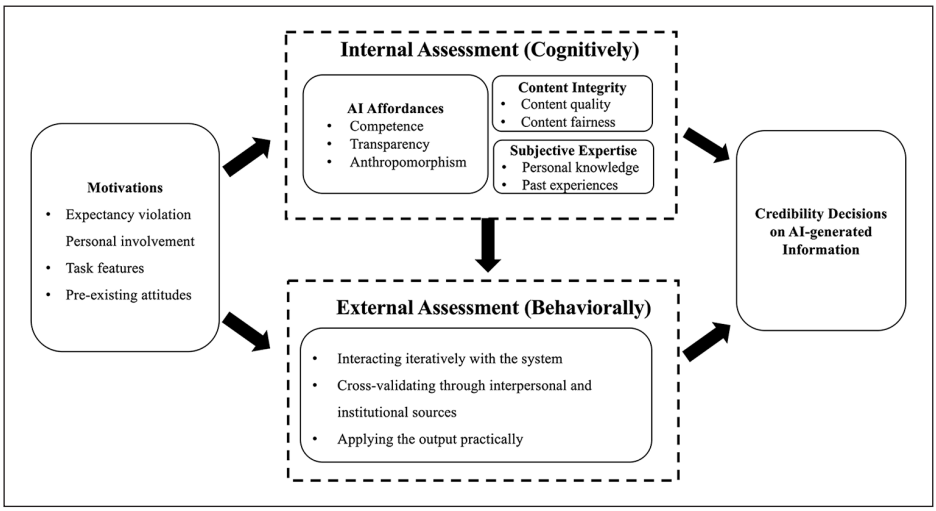

Figure 1. The conceptual framework explicating the underlying motivations and approaches to assessing the credibility of AI-generated information.

grammatically flawed output, he would meticulously review the content himself. Similarly, P7, a university student, stated:

> First off, I trust it. I mean, I start off thinking it's about 80% right, and then I go ahead and ask my questions. As long as the answers don't have any big issues, I trust them right off the bat. After that, I check if the answers are actually correct. But whether to check this part does not happen all the time and really depends on whether if I'm satisfied with what it tells me.

Conversely, some participants (e.g. P19, P23, P26, and P27) expressed that they would accept the AI-provided information without verification if it met or exceeded their expectations, indicating a positive violation of their expectations. P19, who often used generative AI for thesis drafting and formatting, stated,

> Since I have a pretty good sense of what a properly formatted paper should look like, if a generative AI nails the formatting and does it quicker and better than I could myself, I tend to trust it and don't really bother double-checking to make sure it's all correct.

These insights indicate that users' trust in AI is not static but evolves with each interaction, influenced by the AI's ability to consistently meet or exceed the standards expected of it. This suggests a complex interplay of users' expectations, their perceived performance discrepancies, and the resulting impacts on trust and information credibility assessments.

Task features. Users' trust in AI-generated information and their propensity to assess content depend on the nature of their tasks with generative AI (e.g. data analysis, coding, and writing). Participants (P23, P26, and P30) noted that their decision to validate AI

output was influenced by whether they needed factual information or subjective opinions. P30, a journalism student, noted,

> If I need the facts, like when and where an event is happening, I'll definitely double-check to make sure the information is right. But if it's just a matter of opinion, I usually take it as is, no extra verification is needed.

Similarly, P23, a healthcare data analyst, remarked, "When I use it [generative AI] to figure out stuff like regression coefficients, I usually just trust what it spits out and don't bother checking if it's right."

Personal involvement. Personal involvement refers to how relevant an issue or object is to an individual (Zaichkowsky, 1994). Most interviewees reported that they would thoroughly assess the credibility of AI-generated information they deemed it personally significant. P17, employed in the manufacturing industry, shared that he would carefully verify the accuracy of AI-generated information if it were to be utilized in actual product production, stating, "I can't just take what it [generative AI] says at face value, you know? If I did, I could end up with serious financial losses." In a similar vein, P8, an undergraduate studying finance, mentioned,

> For something like an elective course assignment, I might not really check how accurate the stuff from generative AI is. But if it's about something in my field that I care about but don't fully understand, I'll definitely take a closer look at what the AI comes up with, either by using what I know or doing some online research.

Pre-existing attitudes. Results showed that individuals' pre-existing positive attitudes toward generative AI, influenced by their perceptions of its impartiality and fairness, reduced their inclination to verify AI-generated information, as noted by several interviewees (P1, P4, P5, P11). For instance, P4, a freelancer, commented, "Compared to people, generative AI is just a bunch of algorithms, right? It doesn't have any feelings or biases. So, most of the time, I don't bother checking its output because I believe it's got to be impartial." Conversely, individuals' distrust toward generative AI can prompt closer verification of its outputs. P9 illustrated this, explaining,

> While I do use ChatGPT, it doesn't mean I just take everything it says at face value; I don't accept its responses without doing my own checks. If my careful and detailed verification confirms that the content is reliable, then I'm good to go with it.

These comments highlight that individuals' stance on generative AI influences how they make credibility judgments.

Approaches to assessing the credibility of AI-generated information

Interviewees assessed the credibility of AI-generated information using both internal and external approaches. Internal assessments were based on AI affordances, content integrity, and users' own subjective expertise. External assessments involved iterative

interactions with the original AI platforms, cross-referencing with institutional and interpersonal references, and practical application (see Figure 1). This dual approach represents a multifaceted and collaborative human–AI evaluation of the credibility of AI-generated information.

Internal assessment: AI affordances. Affordances refer to the possibilities that an environment or object provides to an individual, shaped through the interplay between the user's objectives and the inherent attributes of the technology (Gibson, 1977). In our study, AI affordances encompass the capabilities and possibilities that an AI system offers to its users, shaped by its design, features, functionality, and interactivity (e.g. Park, 2024; Shin and Park, 2019). The interview data indicated that participants leveraged some AI affordances or system attributes, including competence, transparency, and anthropomorphism (Shin and Park, 2019; Sundar, 2020), to judge the credibility of AI outputs.

Competence. Attributes of generative AI platforms, such as system competence, demonstrated through the advanced algorithmic functions and large databases, shape users' credibility perceptions of AI-generated information. Although users may not fully understand algorithms' technical details, they form their own mental models to conceptualize the system's competence (Bucher, 2017), influencing their trust in the AI and its outputs (Sundar, 2020). In our interviews, most participants (e.g. P2, P14, and P25) stated that their trust in the outputs of generative AI stemmed from its extensive data sources and robust algorithms (i.e. large language models), viewing these as critical for promptly understanding and responding to their queries. P13 remarked, "I have no clue about the calculations behind it, but the algorithms seem super precise. It's way more focused than search engines like Baidu; it totally tailors its responses to your specific questions." P3 emphasized that her trust in a system and its outputs is influenced by the breadth and depth of its databases and algorithms, noting, "The newer and more comprehensive the databases and models it has, the more I tend to trust its outputs. For example, I might place more trust in the results from GPT-4 than those from GPT-3.5."

Transparency. The transparency of AI systems—specifically, the clarity of their algorithmic decision-making processes to users (Ananny and Crawford, 2018; Shin et al., 2024b)—is a frequently mentioned factor in determining whether interviewees trust the information provided by AI systems (e.g. P8 and P14). Users tend to trust AI and its outputs more when they understand the processes involved in data collection, training, and content generation (Rai, 2020; Shin et al., 2024b). However, the increasingly opaque and inexplicable nature of decision-making processes in large language models of generative AI has intensified most interviewees' reluctance to blindly trust its generated information, prompting a greater inclination toward verifying its accuracy. For instance, P14 mentioned, "Although I use this platform, I do not know how it performs calculations or handle private information internally. . . Because I am not familiar with the inner workings of the algorithm, I cannot trust it blindly." In a similar vein, P8 expressed distrust in the AI-generated content, saying, "The algorithms these large language models use are unclear and hard to understand. So, honestly, if it ever comes down to letting them be a doctor or a driver, I'd never trust it."

Anthropomorphism. The degree of trust users place in AI outputs is often influenced by the system's human-like features (i.e. the anthropomorphic attributes of the AI) (Shin, 2022), as highlighted by interviewees (e.g. P3, P5, and P25). Several participants mentioned that during interactions with some generative AI systems, they did not perceive the system as engaging with them in a human-like manner or expressing any emotions, which diminished their trust in the system's responses. P5 stated:

> If it were a version like GPT-3.5 or lower, its answers would actually have a certain mechanical logic, appearing rather stiff and formulaic, making me feel that it is not a human. For example, it likes to use rigid structures such as "firstly," "secondly," and "thirdly." However, if it's GPT-4 or a newer model, or the DAN mode, it can respond to some of my personal questions with a more human-like language. This makes me trust more because I feel it just like a human.

On the other hand, P3 expressed skepticism about AI's ability to handle human emptions, saying, "When I discuss my personal emotional issues, it sometimes only gives me a rather mechanical response that doesn't address my concerns effectively. So, I remain hesitant to fully trust its responses to these matters."

Internal assessment: content integrity. Beyond leveraging AI affordances, participants often scrutinized AI-generated content by focusing on content integrity—assessing its quality (i.e. the accuracy and appropriateness of the content) and fairness (i.e. the ethical dimensions and justice of the output).

Content quality. Interview analysis revealed that most participants assessed the quality of AI-generated content—focusing on the accuracy of semantics, grammar, and style—to determine its credibility. For instance, P7 mentioned, "As long as it appears somewhat logical to me, I will believe it is correct." Similarly, P8 scrutinized the structure and format, noting,

> When I use it [generative AI] to generate texts, the results are generally good, except they typically follow a rigid introduction-body-conclusion format. I usually remove the "conclusion" part to make it appear less machine-generated. Other than that, I trust it a lot.

In addition, some participants, like P9, mentioned that grammatical errors in the generated content reduced their trust, especially when AI-generated academic references were incorrectly formatted.

Content fairness. Content fairness refers to the objectivity, impartiality, and equity in AI-generated content, which are crucial as generative AI increasingly plays a role in decision-making processes (e.g. Shin et al., 2022; Shin and Park, 2019; Sun et al., 2024). Participants like P18 and P25 perceived that AI-generated content appeared less biased and partial than human-generated content, which enhanced their trust. P25 remarked:

> Compared to humans, GPT-4 provides answers that are significantly more logical, fair, and balanced. Its settings help it avoid discrimination, unethical behavior, and violence, and it definitely steers clear of pornography or anything else inappropriate. Overall, it's

> consistently fair and sensible, especially in its rejection of discrimination. I think it handles these issues very well.

However, other interviewees noted biases in some AI-generated content which diminished their credibility perceptions, with P22 stating:

> Occasionally, its responses contained gender biases, potentially because the training data it received contains such biases, and the AI generates text based on the existing corpus; it is also shaped by the biases or prejudices of those who train it.

Internal assessment: subjective expertise. Participants also drew upon their subjective expertise, which encompasses their knowledge and skills acquired through their past experiences and personal learning (Philippe and Ngobo, 1999), to assess AI-generated content. For example, P9, who used AI for drafting literature reviews, mentioned that she typically relied on her past experiences in academic writing to evaluate the adequacy of the AI-generated literature review and to make necessary adjustments. Similarly, P14, who used generative AI to create code for data analysis on software Stata, noted that his fundamental understanding of Stata allowed him to assess the accuracy and usefulness of the AI-generated code. Beyond relying on personal knowledge and experience, other interviewees (P2, P6, P7, and P8) reported that they leveraged their common sense to judge the credibility of outputs from generative AI, with P6 describing, "If it gives me some counterintuitive answers, or if the responses contradict my common sense, I definitely won't use the answers it provides."

External credibility assessment. Most participants reported that when their internal cognitive assessments were insufficient for determining the credibility of information, they turned to external verification methods. In particular, they behaviorally validated the AI-generated information by engaging in strategic iterative interactions with the AI system, cross-validating with external sources, or practical testing of the outputs.

Iterative interaction. Participants reported that they would engage in iterative interactions with AI to check the content they were uncertain about. This process included providing continuous feedback to the AI system, dynamically adjusting their prompts, and relying on AI-driven credibility scoring. P22 recalled:

> When it provided me with references, there was a chance they might be fabricated. At that point, I continuously questioned it, asking whether these references are made up, and it would apologize and admit to its mistakes. I felt that I need to probe again and again until I get more accurate answers.

He contended that the constant adjustment of prompts and provision of feedback would help the system generate credible and satisfying answers. Similarly, P25 assessed the credibility directly on the original platform by requesting AI-driven scoring. He suggested, "The AI could potentially address this issue itself. If you want it to evaluate the reliability of its responses, you could set up a scale for the AI to assess and score the credibility of its own content."

Cross-validation. Except for employing iterative interactions, most participants said they would cross-verify AI-generated content with institutional sources like search engines or academic resources if initial assessments raised doubts about its accuracy. Interviewees, including P8 and P9, specifically mentioned using search engines like Google and Baidu for this purpose. P9 explained, "If I notice some grammatical errors, I will verify them, often by searching on Google, to check whether the content it provides is indeed what I want and whether it is accurate." Other interviewees (e.g. P1) preferred to cross-check with professional sites like Google Scholar when evaluating academic materials produced by AI. Interestingly, some interviewees (e.g. P10 and P23) noted that they cross-checked AI-generated information across various generative AI platforms available in the market (e.g. Wenxinyiyan by Baidu) when they were uncertain about the credibility of information from a specific AI platform, recognizing that each platform had its unique strengths and limitations.

In addition, interviewees often verified the credibility of AI-generated information by consulting interpersonal sources, such as professionals or their colleagues. For example, P14, who used AI for coding, mentioned seeking advice from that AI could not resolve, stating:

> I tend to mentally prioritize the resources I currently have. If the issue cannot be resolved by ChatGPT, then perhaps Google or other software might not be able to, either. In that case, I would seek out authoritative individuals or professionals and consult with them.

P3 mentioned that he validated AI-generated plans with colleagues and supervisors for feasibility. He explained: "If my colleagues or supervisor reach a consensus and think that the plan is feasible, then I will adopt it. However, if we all feel that it is not quite feasible, I will drop it."

Practical testing. For interviewees (e.g. P4, P7, P10, P13, and P23) who often used AI to generate programming codes, they typically validated the accuracy of these codes by running them in their respective programs. P23 explained their process:

> For example, I would use ChatGPT help me write code in languages like JavaScript, Python, and C++. However, the code it generates can sometimes be unreliable, so I polit-run the generated code. It might produce errors when run directly in a compiler. I simply correct those minor bugs until the entire program operates successfully.

This approach reflects a practical method for assessing the credibility of AI-generated information behaviorally through direct testing and iterative debugging.

Discussion

Using an in-depth interview approach, our study explores the diverse strategies and motivations behind individuals' evaluations of AI-generated content. In addressing RQ1, we identified four key motivations for assessing the credibility of AI content. The first motivation is whether the AI-generated content meets or falls short of users' expectations. This finding aligns with the expectancy violation theory (Burgoon,

2015), which suggests that exceeded expectations lead to positive reactions, while unmet expectations result in skepticism and closer scrutiny (Metzger et al., 2010). Our findings extend this theory to the credibility assessment of generative AI content, showing that when AI-generated content fails to satisfy users, it prompts more rigorous scrutiny, whereas content that meets expectations is generally accepted without further verification. By applying expectancy violation theory to the context of AI, our study not only introduces new insights into how users assess the credibility of AI-generated information but also enriches our understanding of the dynamic interplay between users' expectations and AI performance. Furthermore, the findings suggest that expectancy violations could serve as key precursors within the AAA framework, influencing various modes of credibility assessment, both cognitive and behavioral.

Personal involvement and task importance significantly influence individuals' decisions to verify AI-generated information. Those who perceive the information as crucial are more likely to scrutinize it closely. This finding aligns with the dual-processing model of information credibility judgment (Metzger, 2007), which posits that highly involved individuals engage in thorough, systematic evaluations, while those less involved may rely on superficial assessments or bypass verification altogether. Consistent with prior research (Chen et al., 2022), less involved individuals often perceive AI-generated content as higher quality and are less motivated to verify it. This reduced motivation for verification underscores the need to increase personal stake or involvement to encourage more rigorous information authentication, particularly when dealing with AI-generated content of questionable reliability. Our findings extend the dual-processing model by demonstrating its applicability in the context of AI-generated information, emphasizing the critical role of personal involvement in ensuring more accurate credibility assessments.

We also found that prior attitudes toward AI significantly bias individuals' assessments of AI-generated content. Those with favorable views of generative AI systems tend to trust the outputs more readily and are less likely to seek further verification, illustrating how personal biases shape credibility judgments during human–AI interactions. This aligns with biased information-processing theory (e.g. Metzger et al., 2020; Tsang, 2022; Zhou and Shen, 2022), which suggests that credibility judgments are often swayed by alignment with pre-existing attitudes and preferences. Our findings extend this understanding by demonstrating that biases not only affect human–human information exchanges but are also critical in human–AI interactions. Given the impact of personal attitudes on credibility evaluations, future theoretical developments—such as extensions of the AAA model—should explore how these attitudes toward specific technologies or channels influence credibility assessment strategies. This could provide a more comprehensive framework for understanding the dynamics of credibility judgment in the context of AI-generated content.

More importantly, this research identifies the complementary and multidimensional approaches people employ to assess AI-generated information, addressing RQ2. We found that individuals internally evaluate AI-generated content by considering not only informational and personal knowledge factors but also cues stemming from human–AI interaction processes, including AI's competence, transparency, and anthropomorphism.

While previous research has highlighted that AI anthropomorphism (Shin, 2022), system transparency (Shin et al., 2024b), and fairness (Shin and Park, 2019) are important cues for users to decide whether to trust an AI system and its outputs, our study expands on this understanding. We demonstrate the significance of these AI attributes in how people interpret content from generative AI and make credibility judgments. This indicated that the interplay between these cues and users' trust is not static but dynamic, evolving, and constantly changing with each interaction and task assigned to AI.

It is noteworthy that people often engage in strategic iterative interactions with AI platforms for deeper credibility checks when uncertain about the outputs. These interactions exemplify synergistic and mutual-augmentative dynamics in the information credibility assessment process between humans and AI. They not only enhance human efficiency in assessing credibility but also improve the AI system's performance through continuous learning from user feedback. This feedback serves as training for the algorithm, enhancing its future performance. The advent of generative AI may significantly transform people's information verification behaviors by providing more efficient and powerful sources for acquiring validation information. The practice of switching between platforms for credibility checks suggests a potential complementarity among different generative AIs. Future studies could investigate the factors contributing to such platform-switching behaviors.

Theoretical implications

This study offers significant theoretical contributions by introducing a comprehensive framework that integrates diverse motivations and methods for assessing the credibility of AI-generated content. It enriches the theoretical landscape of human–AI interaction and credibility assessment. The key contribution lies in refining the AAA framework by integrating it with the HAII-TIME model, enhancing its relevance for understanding credibility judgments in the AI era.

Specifically, the study enhances traditional internal and external credibility assessments by integrating the roles that AI affordances and human–AI symbiosis play in these mechanisms. On one hand, this theoretical synthesis illustrates how AI affordances such as transparency, competence, and anthropomorphism can enrich the internal credibility assessment processes outlined in the AAA framework. While prior research has identified that these AI features can reduce user uncertainty and enhance trust (e.g. Liu, 2021; Shin et al., 2024b), this study goes further by demonstrating that these features also serve as important cognitive cues for users to internally assess the credibility of AI-generated outputs. This underscores a link between the perceived affordances of AI systems and the trustworthiness attributed to their outputs. On the other hand, this integration also facilitates the refinement of external credibility assessment processes by demonstrating how AI can augment human decision-making in addressing credibility issues, while human inputs and feedback significantly improve the accuracy of AI-generated content. By combining the detailed and comprehensive structure of credibility assessment proposed by the AAA framework with insights on human–AI synergy from the HAII-TIME model, the study presents a richer, more dynamic framework. This integrated approach not only broadens the theoretical base but also provides a

comprehensive lens that encompasses both internal and external credibility assessment methods, weaving in critical aspects of human–AI interactions.

By delineating the multifaceted motivations underlying individuals' credibility assessment of AI-generated content, such as expectation violation, task features, personal involvement, and prior attitudes toward AI, this study refines the AAA framework by identifying the potential precursors to the internal and external credibility assessments. While existing studies have explored the relationships between some of these precursors and technology adoption and trust (e.g. Hong et al., 2021), this study demonstrates that when people interact with emerging technologies like generative AI, their predispositions toward these technologies can lead to different reactions to AI-generated content. In addition, these motivations underscore the necessity of integrating additional theoretical perspectives into the AAA framework to better explain the diverse approaches individuals use in assessing credibility. For example, incorporating expectancy violation theory into the AAA framework could clarify how different types of expectation violations—positive versus negative—affect engagement in credibility assessments. Furthermore, integrating dual-processing and biased information-processing perspectives could elucidate how varying levels of personal involvement and pre-existing attitudes influence the depth of credibility evaluations, ranging from superficial to analytical.

Practical implications

This study offers practical implications for users, platform operators, and regulatory entities. First, given the challenges that generative AI has posed to credibility assessment, users should employ external cross-validation techniques when they are uncertain of the accuracy of AI-generated content. This could involve using tools to perform reverse image searches or checking referenced data against trusted sources to verify content authenticity. Second, since the findings emphasize the need for greater transparency within AI systems, platform operators should consider disclosing the algorithms, data sources, and training processes used in their models. Furthermore, it is important to increase the openness of source models to build user trust. Operators can also invest in AI literacy campaigns that educate users about how AI works, its potential biases, and its broader implications. These campaigns should aim to enhance users' understanding and improve their perceptions of AI credibility and reliability. Third, considering the urgent need for standards and frameworks that ensure the ethical use of AI technologies, regulatory bodies should develop guidelines that enforce transparency, accountability, and fairness in AI deployments. These measures are essential to prevent the misuse of AI technologies and to promote a safer digital environment.

Limitations and future directions

This study has several limitations. First, while the study effectively explores how people assess the credibility of AI-generated information and their motivations using qualitative methods, it does not provide quantitative evidence on how these motivations influence assessment approaches. The qualitative approach we employed is inherently subjective, relying on the interpretations of researchers and coders. Future research should utilize

quantitative methods to empirically investigate how different motivational factors affect credibility assessments, thereby allowing for the testing of statistical relationships. Second, the findings of this study were based on interviews conducted in China, using purposive and snowball sampling strategies, limiting generalizability. Future research could include diverse cultural backgrounds and larger sample sizes to improve cultural insights and extend applicability. Third, the study mainly involves lay users of generative AI, excluding perspectives from experts who might have advanced understanding and detection capabilities. Including a wider range of demographics and expertise in future studies could deepen insights into AI credibility assessments. Finally, the study examines general credibility assessment approaches across AI platforms; comparative analyses on specific platforms (e.g. ChatGPT vs. MidJourney) could uncover differences in how users evaluate information credibility.

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